

Kitchen INSTINCT

Rabri Devi's acerbic attacks on NDA leaders show how the reluctant chief minister has turned into a star campaigner

| By Amitabh Srivastava |

In the years that she was the surrogate chief minister of Bihar, thanks to her marriage certificate, Rabri Devi was known to talk little and work even less, leaving both to her husband—the real power behind the Patliputra throne. But since leaving office, she has begun doing both and appears to be equally artless in either. She hasn't heard about Dale Carnegie or the celebrated techniques on public speaking. On the contrary, she does everything that the blue book on public speaking proscribes—like not preparing her speeches and paying no heed over the delivery of words, and above all by not adhering to politically correct grammar. "I only speak my mind," she says.

In the midst of the rambunctious Lok Sabha elections, Rabri's scathing and acerbic target practice at her opponents has riled NDA leaders. Her belligerent berating of the Nitish Kumar Government and seemingly effortless eye contact with those who gather at her public meetings have made Bihar's Leader of the Opposition one of the best-heard politicians in Bihar and Jharkhand. The insults and abuses she hurls at her opponents keep her in the headlines.

Sample this—Bihar Janata Dal United (BJU) President Rajiv Ranjan

Singh alias Lallan Singh has already filed a criminal defamation suit against her. Nitish has been found arousing the fear factor, saying that if Rabri can abuse a chief minister, imagine what she would do to a commoner if the BJP is voted to power. So, has she distracted the NDA by her acerbic campaigning? Is she a real threat to the NDA's scheme of things in Bihar? Yes and no.

While she has surely succeeded in making the NDA think tank notice and negotiate with her incendiary campaigning, it is equally true that Rabri and her husband Lalu Prasad are up against formidable odds. While on the one hand, Nitish is still riding high on the goodwill of his governance, and the BJP is right behind him in their rock-solid alliance, the Congress on the other hand is also likely to swallow some secular votes as a number of party rebels have joined the enemy camp. Many analysts believe that Rabri may be a good saleswoman but "it's like trying selling a bad product".

"Yes I prepare food in my kitchen. I take care of my husband and children. What else the womenfolk are for? But, should that mean that we be domesticated as Modiji wants me to? The women are not animals, are we?" Rabri questions, demanding an answer. The crowd bellows its disap-



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proval while a few women present at the public meeting shriek—"Never, never". "Then teach the BJP a lesson," Rabri roars waving her arms and piercing the hot dusty air with her war cry. She was referring to Bihar Deputy Chief Minister Sushil Kumar Modi's loaded suggestion that Rabri should better be confined to the kitchen. Modi's rather uncharacteristic reaction to Rabri's alleged personal attack on Nitish has just come unstuck. With a mere flick of her kitchen instinct, the lady has turned it into zilch.

Inarguably, Rabri's public meetings are always well attended, irrespective of the afternoon heat. "Nitish